Policymakers across the world dealing with the impact of the pandemic are now focussed on economic and social recovery. Nations have made decisions in line with their particular circumstances, many conscious that the real challenges still lie ahead. Addressing both lives and livelihood has been an overarching concern for all.

Expectedly, this is India's primary preoccupation too at this time. The pathway to recovery, however, also has steps of resilience that reflect the pandemic experience. These could be in terms of the more direct concerns, as in the health and pharmaceutical sectors. Or they could be broader, covering domestic manufacturing, distribution and consumption. Rapidly creating a pandemic response infrastructure and meeting huge socio-economic needs during a crisis have created a new level of expectations, perhaps more than we realize. If the Indian public has shown commendable fortitude and discipline in the face of adversity, it is in no small measure due to leadership and motivation. However, it is essential to think through strategies that would hasten to put the scars of the pandemic behind us.

In a sense, a foundation for that has been laid by a set of initiatives since 2014. National campaigns addressed a wide range of challenges that were traditionally excluded from the debate on reform. They range from financial inclusion to digital delivery, both on a mass scale; from power and water for all to affordable housing; education and toilets for girls to sanitation and cleanliness; urban planning and rural incomes to accelerating infrastructure building; digitization and formalization to skills development; as well as promoting start-ups, entrepreneurship and innovation. The message was of improving human development indices, leapfrogging using digital tools, empowering the aspirational, and expanding opportunities and benefits. No less important was the fact that transformation was brought about through mobilizing and motivating society at large. By doing so, it finally put behind us the colonial mindset that the people and the government are two different entities. This commitment to societal transformation is clearly appreciated by the public at large.

We must have no illusions about the fact that the road ahead will be a long and arduous one. Looking at the horizon, there are lessons from experiences of others that India needs to imbibe, whether in terms of human resources, social infrastructure or economic capabilities. Basic amenities of power, water and housing can no longer be treated as a luxury. Nor can education, healthcare, skills and employment remain optional for some. In